DRY SPELL TO CONTINUE



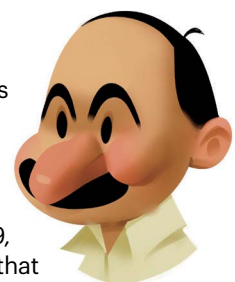
Any lingering hope that Bihar might uncork its prohibition regime after Nitish Kumar's departure has gone flat rather quickly. New chief minister **Samrat Choudhary** made it abundantly clear that there would be no such indulgence. "Who can step back on a programme like prohibition," he remarked, underscoring the fact that there was no going back on his predecessor's commitment. For those bacchanalians hoping against hope that the dry days were over, it's back to staring at their empty glasses woefully, at least for now.

Postings on a Pause



Bureaucratic postings in Madhya Pradesh are dragging on endlessly, with many in the government blaming the alleged disagreements between CM **Mohan Yadav** and his chief secretary (CS) for it. District magistrate postings, pending since November, came through only in mid April. Now we hear it is the IPS's turn to wait. The director general of police (DGP) recently met Yadav to discuss names, where the latter reportedly grilled him on the selections. With both the CS and DGP being Delhi's picks, Yadav is taking his sweet time to say yes or no.

VACATION, NOT VANAVAS



After a hectic campaign, **V.D. Satheesan**, leader of the Opposition in Kerala and Congress candidate from Paravur, spent three days in the forests of Kuttikanam, trekking in the Parunthumpara hills with family and friends. After voting on April 9, Satheesan had cheekily declared that he would quit active politics and go on a *vanavasam* (forest exile, much like Lord Ram's) if the UDF lost the election. Much to the disappointment of rivals, Satheesan captioned his holiday pictures from Kuttikanam: "In forest, not in *vanavas*."

Kaushik Deka with Prasad Nichenametla, Rohit Parihar, Amitabh Srivastava, Rahul Noronha and Jeemon Jacob

HEALTH WATCH

FUNGAL VILLAIN
NEW PERIL IN THE ICU

By **Sonali Acharjee**

If bacteria had their villain era, fungi are quietly writing theirs—no drama, just stubborn persistence. In hospitals, this is now translating into infections that refuse to respond, lingering in the bloodstream and stretching ICU stays.

At the centre of this is Candida auris, a yeast that has become an unwelcome presence in Indian ICUs. Recent Indian surveillance and hospital-based studies flag its growing footprint: a 2023 multicentre analysis published in the *Indian Journal of Medical Microbiology* reported C. auris as a significant contributor to candidemia—a bloodstream infection with high morbidity rates—in tertiary-care ICUs. Clinical outcomes remain worrying—data synthesised in a 2024 review in *Frontiers in Cellular and Infection Microbiology* notes mortality rates ranging from 30 to 60 per cent in severe infections, alongside higher treatment intensity. Meanwhile, post-pandemic analyses, including findings published in *Mycoses* (2023), document a clear uptick in incidence in Indian ICUs compared to pre-COVID baselines, suggesting the pathogen thrives in already strained systems.



What makes C. auris particularly unsettling is not just resistance, but persistence—it clings to skin, surfaces and equipment, making hospital eradication difficult. That shifts the burden from treatment to prevention. India has already seen institutions like AIIMS Delhi strengthen infection-control protocols, but the challenge is scale: uneven surveillance, limited lab capacity, and inconsistent enforcement. The next step is less about new drugs and more about discipline.